

S05-02 - The Ritual Begins

Player text

The Custodian lets out a shrill cry. "The Keystone has finally responded! Surround me, the ritual must begin or I'll lose the pathway! Hurry!" Her glow swells, her eyes roll back, and the carriage lifts a foot off the ground. From the woods comes a chorus of unearthly screeches. The ground rumbles. Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. In the distance, two shapes drift toward you, screeching, wrong. Hold the line until she's done.

Public objective

Begin the defense and understand the countdown.

Raw source

- Id: S05-02
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FIVE
- Sectiontitle: Act Five: The Ward Renewal
- Title: The Ritual Begins
- Shorttitle: Countdown Starts
- Order: 602
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm.png
- Alt: Short Rest Before the Storm scene art for The Ward Renewal.
- Caption: The ritual becomes visible pressure: protect the Custodian and drive the countdown to zero.
- Mood: The Ward Renewal
- Gmgoal: Start the ritual, show the first threats, and put the countdown die on the table.
- Publicobjective: Begin the defense and understand the countdown.
- Readaloud: The Custodian lets out a shrill cry. "The Keystone has finally responded! Surround me, the ritual must begin or I'll lose the pathway! Hurry!" Her glow swells, her eyes roll back, and the carriage lifts a foot off the ground. From the woods comes a chorus of unearthly screeches. The ground rumbles. Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. In the distance, two shapes drift toward you, screeching, wrong. Hold the line until she's done.
- Gmnotes: Market Correction is available as a GM pressure valve, not player-facing terminology.
- Gmscript: Say: "d8, starting at 8. Defeat an enemy or remove a real pressure, it ticks down one. She gets hit or exposed, it ticks up one. At zero, the ritual is done and you win. The math is simple; staying alive is not."
- Gmreadaloud: "The Keystone has finally responded! Surround me, the ritual must begin or I'll lose the pathway!" The carriage lifts a foot off the ground. Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. Two shapes drift in the

distance, screeching, wrong.

- Gmchecklist: Place Custodian center, PCs around her, 4 rusted-sword skeletons Close, and 2 screeching wraiths Far. Set ritual_countdown=8. If ward_stability=stable, soften the first exposure or give a prepared defense a free success beat; if fragile or missing, full canon pressure. If ritual_prep=ready, let the prepared PC explain the countdown in character. Initialize protected_whom as unresolved and start watching who covers whom.
- Gmprivate: Use description before names: rusted-sword dead, floating screeching wraiths. Names and deeper meaning can come after the table understands what they see.
- Playertakeaway: This is the fight that ends the story: keep her safe and run the clock down.
- Storytakeaway: The ritual is live and irreversible now; the only way out is through.
- Mechanictakeaway: The countdown die is the win condition: d8 starts at 8, down on enemy defeat or pressure removed, up when the Custodian is hit.
- Rollcards: s05-02-use-the-short-rest-with-intention S05-02 Use the short rest with intention Use the short rest with intention Presence Finesse Knowledge Presence Finesse, Knowledge 10 Presence tends emotions; Finesse repairs gear; Knowledge prepares the field. The rest becomes bookkeeping instead of care before danger. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The rest becomes bookkeeping instead of care before danger. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or...
- Entityids: open-valetm-ritual-site whitefire-custodian keystone-asset old-sable short-rest khari-nix
- Entities: open-valetm-ritual-site Open Vale? Ritual Site location Location assets/icons/location.png assets/location-visuals/open-valetm-ritual-site/profile_scene_v02.png OH-pen vayl RICH-oo-ul site An ancient circular clearing of standing stones and ward-light, with a freshly painted company marker staked at its edge. Make the final arena feel sacred, neglected, and operational all at once. Ancient circular clearing rebranded by Goldspire; where the ward renewal happens.; introduce it with a sensory palette, who feels safe there, and what has been neglected. Pull player attention toward the choices, clues, and relationships tied to Whitefire Custodian, Keystone Asset, Legacy Security Skeleton. Ancient circular clearing rebranded by Goldspire; where the ward renewal happens. whitefire-custodian Whitefire Custodian npc NPC / Ally assets/icons/npc.png assets/npc-images/whitefire-custodian/portrait_base.png WHITE-fire kus-TOH-dee-un Old faerie-like custodian who maintains the ward protecting Hush. Truth-bearer for the Keystone reveal. Whitefire Custodian an old faerie-like ward keeper whose exhaustion glows around the edges Ancient kindness running on fumes, glowing a little brighter whenever...
- Locationids: open-valetm-ritual-site old-sable

- Statecontrols: ritual_prep Ritual Prep select unready ready keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding select surface deep protected_whom Protected Whom select unresolved custodian party hush shared strixwolf_disposition Strixwolf Disposition select unresolved calm hostile killed strixwolf_outcome Strixwolf Outcome select unresolved calmed helped avoided attacked killed strixwolf_trust Strixwolf Trust number 3 strixwolf_blood_debt Strixwolf Blood Debt checkbox bramble_outcome Bramble Outcome select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped let_cargo bramble_truth_learned Bramble Truth Learned checkbox package_status Package Status select held lost hush_trust Hush Trust select low neutral high custodian_route Custodian Route select unknown safe dangerous ward_awareness Ward Awareness select none seed aware festival_boon Festival Boon select none charm favor market_find goodwill custodian_trust Custodian Trust select low neutral high ward_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable hush_clues Hush Clues select none custodian_route ward_seed corporate_seam farm_seed market_rumor multiple ritual_countdown Ritual Countdown number 10 8 ritual_outcome Ritual Outcome select unresolved...
- Mechanicids: short-rest stress armor-slots hope countdown fear difficulty action-roll table-spotlight
- Playerquestions: Who stands closest to her? Who calls the first target? Who watches the far shapes instead of the skeletons?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in Short Rest Before the Storm that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Choicesconsequences: Surround the Custodian. The party starts with bodies between her and danger. Good positioning can prevent the first +1 tick. protected_whom begins with Custodian protection. protected_whom=custodian Reward: safer center. player-visible Prioritize early defeats. The countdown starts moving down fast. Each defeated adversary ticks ritual_countdown -1. The fight feels winnable before wraith pressure escalates. ritual_countdown -1 per defeat Reward: clock momentum. player-visible Leave her exposed. A threat can reach the center. Custodian hit/exposure ticks ritual_countdown +1. custodian_fate may worsen by S05-06. ritual_countdown +1; custodian_fate trends drained Penalty: delayed ritual. player-visible
- Lootclues: One named preparation boon One final question answered
- Handoutids: Custodian composure
- Sourcescenelug: S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_MAPS_AND_LOCATIONS.md
- References: Ritual arena #MAP-S05-03
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unlicensed soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."
REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-

credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulsfire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Instinct: target logic. Knowledge: read markings. ACT5 Act 5: Open Vale defense 200 2:40 to 3:20 3:20 countdown 8, skeletons, wraiths, Market Correction Lower the countdown start to 6; cap wraith reinforcements.

- Livetools: encounter S05-02 MAP-S05-03 pages/combat/s05-03.html
- Percharacterlayer: marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind Assist the opening Can lend power to the Custodian's opening without making the plot depend on her. Knowledge 13 May ease the opening pressure or explain the countdown diegetically if ritual_prep is ready. Can make the rules feel like fiction. Marlowe, you could lend power to her opening and ease the clock. Want to try? garrick-reed Garrick Reed Threat read Instantly triages the field: four melee dead, two ranged soul-things, center to protect. Can call targets and priorities. Garrick, you've read a hundred fights. Want to call the party's targets? khari-nix Khari Nix Anchor Can plant herself as the Custodian's body-shield. Can become the formation's immovable center without being the only solution. Khari, you're the wall between her and the dead. Want to anchor on the Custodian? varian-soto Varian Soto Far shapes Can distinguish rusted bodies from soul-cold wraith pressure by sound and smell. Can warn the table which threat is about to matter. Varian, the far shapes sound wrong in a different way. What do you warn them about? barnacle Barnacle Loose lane Sees the lane nobody official planned for. Can cover an exposed angle or exploit terrain...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway This is the fight that ends the story: keep her safe and run the clock down. "Surround her. Drop what comes. Do not let them touch her. Get the die to zero." "Pick a threat, body-block the Custodian, or call a target. Every enemy down is a tick toward the end." Make the next action obvious for overwhelmed players. countdown fear difficulty Story takeaway The ritual is live and irreversible now; the only way out is through. "No stopping this now. She is committed. The clock is running, and it runs on how well you protect her." "The dead are clawing up and the wraiths are drifting in because the magic woke something that answers pressure." Do not name the corporate meaning yet. countdown fear difficulty Mechanic takeaway The countdown die is the win condition: d8 starts at 8, down on enemy defeat or pressure removed, up when the Custodian is hit. "d8, starting at 8. Defeat an enemy, it ticks down one. She gets hit, it ticks up one. At zero, the ritual is done and you have won." "ward_stability stable means a kinder opening; fragile or missing means full pressure. ritual_prep ready means someone can explain this before the first hit." Keep updates visual and verbal...
- Playerbeats: s05-02-response Response The Keystone responds assets/scenes/S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm.png Short Rest Before the Storm scene art for The Ward Renewal. The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. text-first s05-02-dead-rise Threats The dead rise assets/scenes/S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm.png Short Rest Before the Storm scene art for The Ward Renewal. Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. Two wrong shapes drift from the woods. Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. Two wrong shapes drift from the woods.

Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. Two wrong shapes drift from the woods. text-first s05-02-countdown Countdown The die hits the table assets/scenes/S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm.png Short Rest Before the Storm scene art for The Ward Renewal. The countdown starts at 8. Defeat threatens to move it down; protect the Custodian so it does not move up. The countdown starts...

- Gmbeats: s05-02-response Response The Keystone responds Say: "The ritual is live. She cannot stop now without losing the pathway." The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. The party crosses from prep into irreversible action. The scene shifts to countdown play. Players know the ritual has begun. Player takeaway Players know the ritual has begun. "The ritual is live. She cannot stop now without losing the pathway." "The table-facing answer is: Players know the ritual has begun." Use this beat to give the players one visible next action: protect the center, read the field, spend prep, name who they shield, or choose what truth leaves with them. countdown Story takeaway The party crosses from prep into irreversible action. "The ritual is live. She cannot stop now without losing the pathway." "The story answer is: The party crosses from prep into irreversible action." Tie the answer to a visible Act 5 consequence: the ward steadies, the Custodian suffers, Hush is protected, or the final report changes who owns the truth. countdown Mechanic takeaway The scene shifts to countdown play. "The ritual is live. She cannot stop now without losing the..."
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8500
- Playersafeprojection: S05-02 scene The Ritual Begins assets/scenes/S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm.png Short Rest Before the Storm scene art for The Ward Renewal. The ritual becomes visible pressure: protect the Custodian and drive the countdown to zero. The Ward Renewal Begin the defense and understand the countdown. The Custodian lets out a shrill cry. "The Keystone has finally responded! Surround me, the ritual must begin or I'll lose the pathway! Hurry!" Her glow swells, her eyes roll back, and the carriage lifts a foot off the ground. From the woods comes a chorus of unearthly screeches. The ground rumbles. Rusted swords break the surface as dead things claw their way up. In the distance, two shapes drift toward you, screeching, wrong. Hold the line until she's done. s05-02-response Response The Keystone responds assets/scenes/S05-02-short-rest-before-the-storm.png Short Rest Before the Storm scene art for The Ward Renewal. The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. The Custodian cries out, the Keystone answers, and the carriage lifts from the ground. text-first...
- Companionmapids: MAP-S05-03 MAP-LOC-open-valetm-ritual-site MAP-LOC-old-sable
- Slidenumbers: 66
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-COUNTDOWN the-countdown the-countdown M18 S05-02 high mandatory scene-enter The Ritual Countdown The finale clock is teachable math. Start the countdown at 8. Defeat an adversary or neutralize meaningful pressure: -1. Custodian hit or exposed: +1. When it reaches 0, the ritual completes. Countdown mechanics wiki/mechanic/the-countdown teach-by-example Make the finale win condition visible to the table. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True
- Spotlightsummary: 1

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